

As the fighting intensifies, refugees are fleeing the region in droves. Entire families are coming in trucks, in buses, in rickshaws, in pickups and on foot. Most have only the clothes on their backs and have walked for tens of miles to get out of Swat, Buner and Dir districts during short relaxations of the army-imposed curfews. They have abandoned their homes, their standing crops and their cattle. Some have lost family members. All have stories to tell of bombs falling from the sky and fierce gunbattles between the army and the Taliban, but such is the terror that very few want to talk. Exhausted, hungry and bedraggled, they look dismayed at the further indignities they must suffer

at the hastily set-up camps for internally displaced persons, which have no running water, no toilet facilities, no electricity and where they must sleep on plastic mats in cloth tents and stand in long queues to have food ladled out to them in plastic bags. "My family and I walked for 25 miles before we found a pickup to bring us here," says an exasperated Asmatullah Khan, who fled from outside Mingora in Swat. "We have nothing with us but there is nothing here either. Yesterday we only got food at midnight but there were no plates or bowls or even buckets to take it in. We are like animals here."

Inside Mardan city, where three camps were set up to house those af-

fectured by the army's latest operation against militants, the camps are already full. A banner hangs at the entrance to the Sheikh Yasin camp, the last of the three to be set up, informing those coming in that there is no more space left in the camp and that new arrivals should go to the Mansoor camp in the neighbouring Swabi district. Sheikh Yasin was established only two days earlier, on May 10. And this is only the tip of the iceberg. More than 85-90 per cent of the displaced people are not even at the camps, opting instead to stay with relatives or friends at least in the immediate term. The number of internally displaced persons (IDPs) in Pakistan from this and other military

